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U.T. El Paso Miners Open 1972 Baseball Campaign

Warm, sunny afternoons and stifling dust storms mean one thing in the Land of the Sun—baseball season is near.

The University of Texas at El Paso baseball squad will be fighting a glaring lack of experience as it opens the 1972 campaign Saturday in a twin-bill against Ranger J. C. at Dudley Field.

Miner head coach Andy Cohen has called this his "youngest team ever at U.T. El Paso."

Only eight lettermen return from last year's Miners squad that posted a 24-26 record. Of those eight returning, only three started last year.

Those three returning front liners are Barry Alburtis, a sleek left handed first sacker from Lubbock, Skip Baker, a steady, scrappy second baseman from Parkland High School and Tim Peden, a solid backstop at catcher from Kermit. Clint Newsome, a capable receiver, saw lots of action filling in for Peden last season.

Aside from these three, the Miners are low on experience and several freshmen should break into the lineup.

The Miners will be battling in what may be the nation's strongest baseball conferences. Arizona State, Arizona and New Mexico comprise the Southern Zone of the Western Athletic Conference will put the young Miners to the acid test.

The Miners were fourth last year with a 6-12 mark.

Arizona State is a perennial collegiate power and in recent years Arizona and New Mexico have fielded fine ball clubs. Brigham Young, last year's WAC champion, took third the college World Series.

Cohen said, "We lost some good ball players, especially our power hitters. We're hoping our youngsters can step right in and do the job for us."

MINERS PREPPING

The Miners have been preparing for the season under the watchful eyes of a baseball-wise trio. Cohen is getting help from his brother, Sid, and Ronnie White, a newcomer from Odessa.

The venerable Cohen, dubbed the "Silver Fox" by his charges, suffered a stroke this winter and the personable mentor is recovering rapidly. However, Andy tires easily and cannot take the active part in Miners practice sessions that he has been accustomed.

This is where White comes into his own. White, who guided two Odessa American Legion ball clubs to the state tournament, takes the reins and workouts proceed without a hitch. White has become Andy's right hand man.

It has been said that pitching is 90 per cent of baseball. That being the case, Andy has an able assistant in brother Sid. Sid is in charge of the pitchers and has helped turn out several professional hurlers.

Jim Greggerson and Marc Bombard, both solid mound performers for the Miners, have inked pro contracts while under Sid's wing.

This year's version of the Miners will feature improved team speed. The infield, in particular, has shown quick hands and feet.

Andy calls his pitching the big question mark. "We've got some good young arms but I'm still looking for pitchers," Andy added.

Sid lists eight pitchers on the ball club, four right handers and four southpaws.

Ernie Carreon, a senior right hander, heads the list as he posted the best earned run average of any returning hurlers—a 4.62. Carreon tabbed a 1-1 won-loss record.

Phil Darwin, the only other returning pitcher, is a sophomore rightie from Coronado High. Darwin was 1-4 last year and posted a 6.61 ERA.

Mike Beltran, a promising junior transfer from Ranger J.C., could shore up the leaks that may develop in the Miners pitching.

Richard Iagger, a sophomore transfer from Ranger J.C., is rated a top prospect.

Tony Eaton is a lefthander that Sid is counting on for some fine performances. Eaton is a freshman from Andress High.

Ray Greggerson, brother of former Miner star Jim, is rated a "comer" by Sid. Greggerson is from Ysleta High School.

Tim Peden, the starting catcher last year, could be a big surprise if he can make the battery transition. Peden, at 6-foot-2 and 205 pounds, is being counted upon by Sid to give the Miners mound staff a fireballer.

Joel Kinstler and Frank Del Toro can play other positions but have been receiving attention from the Miners hierachy for their pitching talents. Both are freshmen left handers.

Andy insists that his lineup is not set yet and that he will cut the 35-man squad to"23 or so" before the Saturday doubleheader.

BATTLE ROYALE

A battle royale is raging at several key positions as the Miners are coiling for the opening ball games.

In left field, Loli Maldonado and Eloy Alvarado seem to have the inside tracks. Maldonado is a freshman from El Paso High, and has good speed. Coach White said of Alvarado, "He can help us because he's versatile and he'll hustle."

Center field is anchored by Malcom MacLean and Joe Hernandez. MacLean is a frosh from Hampton, Va. while Hernandez hails from Austin High here in El Paso.

One of the big position battles is in right field. Two fine ball players are fighting for the job. They are Joel Kinstler, a freshman from Odessa and Joe Pennies, another frosh from Coronado. Both are rated fine prospects and show raw talent in preseason drills.

Kinstler can pitch and swings a good bat. Pennies is a top athlete and plays for the Miner freshman basketball squad in his spare time. Pennies is a switchhitter.

Who's on first? Barry Alburtis, a returning starter, is anchored at the position but he is getting pressure from junior transfer Frank Del Toro. Both are left handers all the way.

Alburtis hit .269 for the Orange last season and says, "Thats bound to go up!"

Del Toro is getting the Cohen look-see at first, in the outfield and on the mound.

Terry Baker, the stocky second sacker, may be the rock of the infield. "Skip," as he is called by his teammates, rapped out a solid .294 season average last year, second highest among the returnees. Bobby Hess is Baker's main competition.

Baker is a junior from Parkland High School while Hess is a freshman from Hampton, Va. White says of Hess,"He'll fool you. He's got a pretty good stick."

Competition is keen at the crucial shortstop post. A slick shortstop is a must. Larry Honeycutt and Ernie Hernandez are in glove-to-glove competition for the job.

Honeycutt is a freshman from Roswell, N.M. and rated a sure-handed fielder with a decent bat. Hernandez is a junior from Bel Air High and White says, "He could be a good one."

Third base is wide open as three players are struggling for supremacy. Max Swafford, of Kermit, is rated the best fielder of the trio but Jan Hood, a sophomore from Lubbock, is rated the best hitter. The third member of the trio is Bobby Morales who is one of the two seniors on the ball club.

Hood is football refuge who has shown power at the dish while Morales may be tabbed for outfield duty.

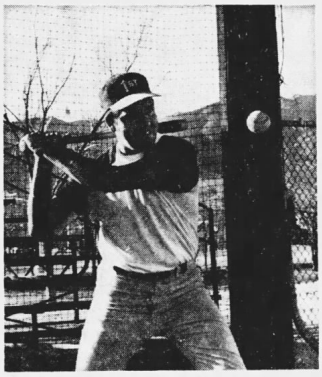
Clint Newsome, a junior from Parkland High, can handle the all important catching chores when Peden is on the mound. Peden may see double duty in twin-bills, pitching the first game and catching the nightcap.

Newsome hit .316 in 36 plate appearances last year.

Eloy Alvarado, a versatile performer, can also fill in behind the plate.

The Miners play a 55 game schedule this year. All but 11 of those contests will be at home in Dudley Field.

The Big Orange rest for week after the Ranger doubl header when they meet Texa Tech at home.



COHEN'S LIEUTENANT — *Ronnie White, new assistant baseball coach from Odessa, is shown hitting fungoes to the infield during a recent practice session at Hugo Mayer Park. White has stepped in and helped guide the Miners through early season drills.*



MINER MAINSTAYS — *These two ball players must shoulder the load if the Miners are to improve last year's 6-12 WAC record. Barry Alburtis (1) is a slick first baseman from Lubbock and a returning starter. Tim Peden started at catcher last season but Coach Andy Cohen may call on his strong arm to pitch. Peden is a junior from Kermit.*

1972 BASEBALL SCHEDULE

THE UNIVERSITY OF TEXAS AT EL PASO

2-26-72	Ranger Junior College	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3- 3-72	Texas Tech	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3- 4-72	Texas Tech	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3- 8-72	West Texas State	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3- 9-72	West Texas State	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
3-10-72	Texas Tech	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3-11-72	Texas Tech	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
3-16-72	Denver University	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
3-17-72	Denver University	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3-18-72	Southern Colorado State	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3-20-72	Colorado State	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
3-21-72	Colorado State	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
3-24-72	New Mexico Highlands	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
3-25-72	New Mexico Highlands	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3-27-72	Lubbock Christian College	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3-28-72	Lubbock Christian College	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3-29-72	Artesia College	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
3-31-72	Northern Illinois University	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
4- 1-72	Northern Illinois University	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
4- 3-72	Regis College	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
4- 4-72	Regis College	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
4- 7-72	University of Arizona	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
4- 8-72	University of Arizona	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
4-11-72	New Mexico State	Las Cruces, N.M.	2 Games
4-14-72	Arizona State University	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
4-15-72	Arizona State University	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
4-21-72	New Mexico University	El Paso, Texas	1 Game
4-22-72	New Mexico University	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
4-25-72	New Mexico State Univ.	El Paso, Texas	2 Games
4-28-72	University of Arizona	Tucson, Arizona	1 Game
4-29-72	University of Arizona	Tucson, Arizona	2 Games
5- 5-72	Arizona State University	Tempe, Arizona	1 Game
5- 6-72	Arizona State University	Tempe, Arizona	2 Games
5-12-72	New Mexico University	Albuquerque, N.M.	1 Game
5-13-72	New Mexico University	Albuquerque, N.M.	2 Games

Canton Slates Annual Contest

CANTON, Ohio (AP) — The annual Pro Footbal Hall of Fame game will be played in Canton's Fawcett Stadium July 29, it was announced recently.

The game, 10th in the series, will pit the Kansas City Chiefs of the American Football Conference against the New York Giants of the National Conference.

Several persons will be enshrined into the Hall that day, including Lamar Hunt, owner and founder of the Chiefs, who were originally known as the Dallas Texans.

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